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California lawmakers take trip to Israel amid growing criticism of war in Gaza

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A group of California lawmakers are on a three-day trip to Israel this week amid growing criticism from U.S. leadership over that country's conduct in its war against Hamas in Gaza.

In a statement, lawmakers said they will "meet with impacted communities and bear witness to the devastation caused by the October 7th Hamas attack and resulting Israel-Hamas war, both of which have had significant impacts on communities across California."

Elected officials on the trip include Democratic Sens. Scott Wiener of San Francisco and Henry Stern of Los Angeles, and Democratic Assemblymembers Jesse Gabriel of Woodland Hills, Esmeralda Soria of Fresno, Damon Connolly of San Rafael, Josh Lowenthal of Long Beach and Al Muratsuchi of Torrance.

The California delegation said in a statement they will meet Israeli President Isaac Herzog and Arab politicians who represent Palestinian citizens of Israel, as well as families of Israeli hostages, advocates for victims of sexual assault and peace activists.

In addition, the group said it plans to visit kibbutz Kfar Aza, an Israeli community devastated by the Hamas attack, as well as the site of the Supernova Music Festival where hundreds of young partygoers were killed, according to the statement.

It's unclear if the lawmakers will be hearing from Gazans or Palestinians living under Israeli military occupation in the West Bank.

The trip is sponsored and led by major California Jewish communal organizations, including the Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles, Jewish Public Affairs Committee of California and the San Francisco Jewish Community Relations Council.

Gov. Gavin Newsom visited Israel in October soon after the Hamas attack on his way to China, meeting with victims of the Hamas attack and traveling to Gaza border communities.

After Hamas led deadly attacks in Israel on Oct. 7 that Israeli authorities say killed 1,200 people and abducted more than 250 others, Israel has conducted intense bombing and ground campaigns in Gaza that Palestinian authorities say have killed more than 28,000 people including 12,000 children.

In the months since the war began, California has seen dozens of protest actions and demonstrations demanding a cease-fire in the region. Several have been in Sacramento, including one that disrupted a legislative session.

California is home to the largest population of Arab Americans in the United States, according to the Arab American Institute. It also has the second largest populations of Jewish residents in the U.S., according to the American Jewish Population Project at Brandeis University.

Elected leaders of the state have been divided over their position on the war.

Several state lawmakers have called publicly for a ceasefire, including Assemblymembers Alex Lee of San Jose, Matt Haney of San Francisco and Liz Ortega of Hayward.

Others, including co-chairs of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, Wiener and Gabriel, have said they hold personal criticisms of Israel's far-right government but do not support a ceasefire.

Wiener has also highlighted an uptick in antisemitism faced by the state's Jewish communities since October, including bomb threats.

He said demonstrators "crossed lines" this week when some surrounded his car, accusing him of "killing babies" and followed him, saying "your whole bloodline's cowards."

In recent days, Israel has continued to warn of a looming invasion in Rafah, the southern Gaza city that is sheltering more than one million people. Aid groups say an invasion would collapse the humanitarian response to an already severe humanitarian crisis.

President Joe Biden has been increasingly critical of Israel's conduct in its war against Hamas, calling Israel's response "over the top" this week and arguing for the need to more precisely target Hamas militants while minimizing humanitarian deaths.

Despite the criticism, Biden has continued to approve arms sales to Israel and is urging Congress to send more aid. Recent talks between Israel and Hamas in Cairo ended on Tuesday without an agreement to pause the fighting.

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